

COLLATERAL DAMAGE Ousted MLA and Singh's wife Neelam Devi; below, Nitish Kumar

grimly went about its rituals, citing Singh's insubordination and 'unparliamentary language' to expel him for six years, along with his wife and ex-MLA, Neelam Devi. It also asked the Speaker to initiate disqualification proceedings against him.

But the swagger in the mustachioed strongman's words only increased. It hardly seemed to matter when, on October 28, the JD(U) won the MLC poll, which measures the mood in a limited, registered graduate electorate. Singh declared the party "finished", predicting it would not win even 10 seats in the next assembly poll, declaring for good measure that he might float his own party.

A LARGER LIMBO

Singh's remarks can't be dismissed as the bluster of a lone insurrectionist, with no wider relevance. The JD(U) can perhaps say goodbye to Mokama for now. The chieftain has it all sewn up, having taken it as a JD(U) nominee, as an Independent who beat the official candidate in 2015, and as an RJD candidate from jail. But his revolt also shows where the JD(U) is at: a low ebb, despite being in the ruling alliance with 85 MLAs.

It has entered this limbo because it has no second-rung leader with a statewide appeal. No one within a country mile of the man it's synonymous with: Nitish Kumar, who exited centrestage in April, months after swinging one more historic election. His record as one of Bihar's most astute politicians is now spoken of largely in the past tense; with limited public interaction, Nitish has slipped into semi-retirement, available to the party mostly as a silhouette against a quiet sunset.

Post-Nitish, the JD(U) is seen as a divided house: one section is pro-BJP and favours walking in lockstep with 'Big Brother', another is fiercely protective of the JD(U)'s autonomy and old socialist identity. Nitish in his time could balance opposites. In his slipstream, working president Sanjay Jha, Union minister and former national president Lalan Singh, deputy CMs Vijay Choudhary and Bijendra Prasad Yadav, all are seasoned hands, but sans that same agglomerative effect. Nitish's son Nishant, health minister, is seen as learning the ropes.



Takeaways

- **JD(U) expels Anant Singh for six years**
- **Mokama MLA's riposte: it won't even get 10 seats**
- **Lack of second rung of leadership causing drift**

That led to the softness where an MLA could openly campaign against the party and stay an MLA until after polling. Singh himself supplied the diagnosis. "The party belonged to Nitish. Now that he's no longer there, what's left of it?" he asks. Exaggerated for effect, but evidence that the 'United' in Janata Dal (United) now sounds more like an aspiration than a description. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

THE BENGAL

It's a ticking counter: dozens of attac

By **Arkamoy Dutta Majumdar**

IT WAS DURGA PUJA, A TIME THAT HAS HISTORICALLY created a sense of common festive bonding. A spirit that tends to spill beyond the overt religious markers, harking back instead to ancient seasonal carnivals in everyone's blood—like during Holi, Christmas or Onam. In Chandrakona village of Paschim Medinipur, however, it brought fear. Three Christian families were allegedly assaulted, threatened with violence and coerced into performing Hindu rituals after they refused to renounce Christianity. One woman alleged she was subjected to a public purification ritual. Far from an isolated instance, it brought an uncomfortable question into focus yet again: what does West Bengal's first Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government mean for its religious minorities?

SERIAL ASSAULTS

After the families reported incidents between October 18 and 20, an FIR was registered naming 13 accused, but no arrests had been made even after a week. Police merely say they have provided security and are investigating. The allegations, if established, would constitute a grave violation of religious freedom. At present, that predicament seems to be widely shared. The Bongiyo Chritiyo Pariseba (BCP), an apex body for Christians in Bengal, says that between June and October, it has recorded over 46 incidents of hate against Christians across Bengal. Its founder, Herod Mullick, claims the exact number would be much higher. Not implausible, since an India Hate Lab report had documented 60 such alleged crimes across 13 districts just between May 13 and September 20.

The alleged incidents include raids